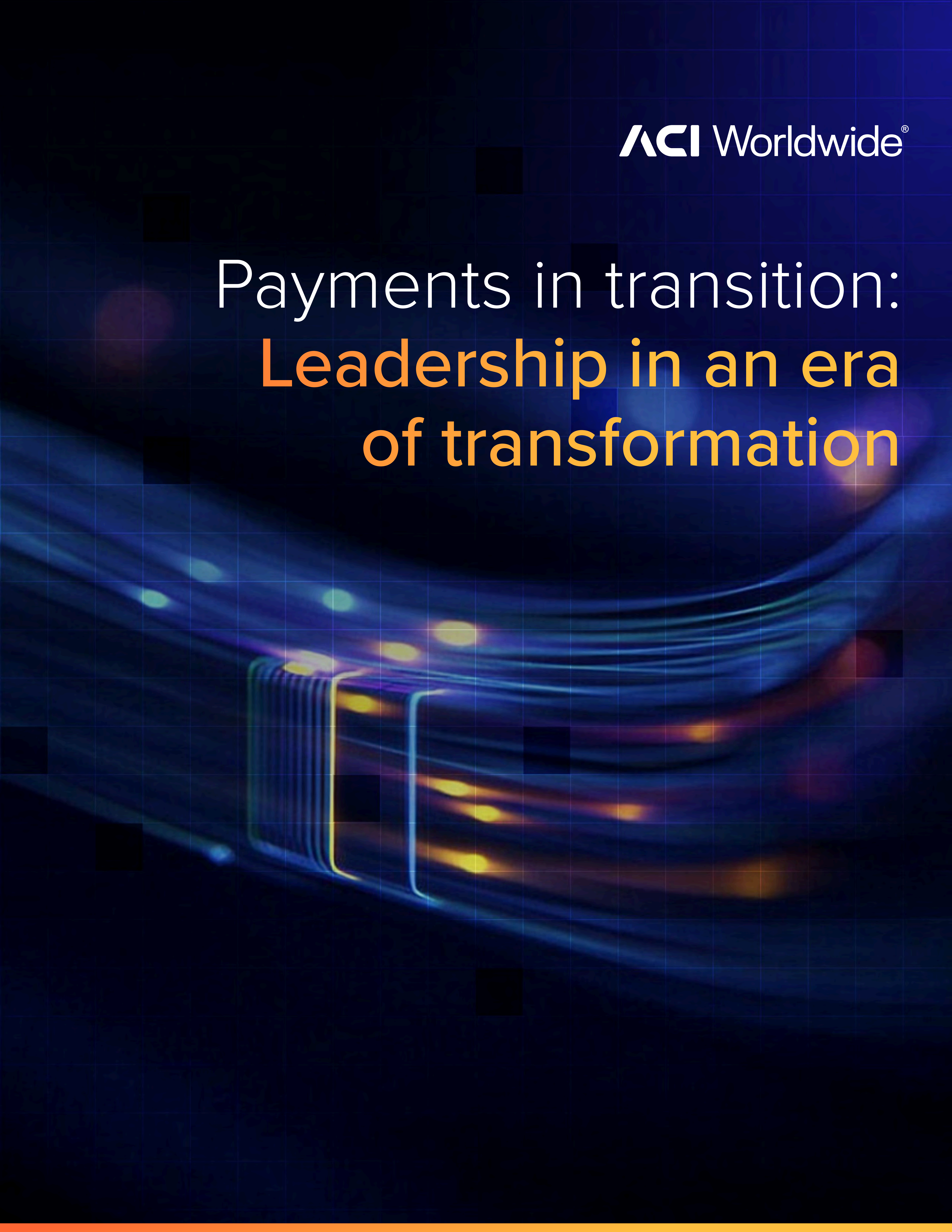


Payments in transition: Leadership in an era of transformation



Report outline

01 Foreword

02 Introduction: The payments market imperative for the decades ahead

- LAYER ONE

03 Critical barriers and drivers – Navigating a landscape of requirements

04 The perception paradox: Leadership vs. readiness

05 Confronting the barriers: The forces holding back progress

06 The engines of change: Forces driving the industry forward

07 The duality of regulations, standards, and requirements: Barrier and driver

08 Summary

- LAYER TWO

09 The leadership blueprint – Forging advantage amid increasing complexity

10 The anatomy of leadership

12 The leadership blueprint

13 Pillar 1: Executive ownership & long-term vision

14 Pillar 2: Capability and talent activation

15 Pillar 3: Agility and future readiness

16 Summary

- LAYER THREE

17 An ecosystem in transition – Implications for navigating a space of rapid change

18 Ecosystem shift 1: The modernization of payments

19 Ecosystem shift 2: Advancing protection, trust, and identity

20 Ecosystem shift 3: Maximizing performance in the era of automation

21 Conclusion: Optimizing performance and protection through modernization in a changing ecosystem

22 ACI Worldwide: Your partner in navigating the future of payments

Foreword

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Whether it’s paying a bill, purchasing goods or doing a transaction at a bank, payments have never felt easier for consumers. A tap, a swipe, or a process so integrated that it’s automatic, and customers expect it to work. Yet behind that simplicity, the industry is facing growing complexities defined by a dynamic state of requirements pushing and pulling the market. The industry is held back by persistent barriers that hinder innovation and modernization, while powerful forces impacting experiences push the industry forward, driving progress simultaneously.

On one side, increasing functionality, proliferating payment types and methods, tightening regulation, rising fraud costs, and outdated infrastructure are adding complexity. Legacy systems, even with ongoing enhancement over time with custom code and downstream system integrations, simply can’t keep pace with a real-time economy. These legacy systems slow innovation and create financial risk by tying up cash flow through delayed receivables and latent reconciliation cycles. Solutions like intelligent payment hubs offer a practical answer to overcoming traditional barriers and letting companies meet the ever-evolving customer expectations.

On the other side, innovation continues at high speeds. Real-time payment rails are proliferating globally. Alternative payment methods are expanding. Artificial intelligence is enhancing decision-making capabilities and opening new doors for value-added services. AI has become a necessary tool for sharpening fraud detection, improving sanctions screening, strengthening risk models and improving liquidity management through intelligent routing. Agentic commerce is beginning to take hold, improving customer experiences with digital assistants and contextual triggers influencing purchasing decisions on behalf of consumers and businesses.

Together, the market push-pull and underlying forces are impacting how money moves, and ratcheting up the competitive stakes. Those who wish to lead the market will need to navigate and address the persistent barriers and advancing innovation simultaneously. Capturing the momentum of emerging technologies means being able to remove structural barriers to gain market share, grow revenue and optimize ROIs. For every player in payments, that means making modernization a strategic priority, building resilience as conditions shift, increasing protection, and strengthening the capabilities to exceed customer expectations. Those who do will be the ones to truly influence the payments industry topography.

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